POPIA and Digital Privacy Module
Section 5: Protecting Your Digital Privacy

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

Throughout this module you have learned what POPIA is, what rights it gives you, how data gets misused, and what organisations are legally required to do. This final section brings everything together from your side of the equation. Knowing your rights and understanding the law is important, but the most practical thing you can do is take steps to actively protect your own digital privacy.

Practical Steps to Protect Your Personal Information

Think before you share

Before you fill in any form, sign up for any service, or share any document in a group chat, ask yourself three questions: Does this organisation actually need this information? Is there a legitimate reason they are asking for it? What could happen if this information ended up in the wrong hands?

Limit what you share on social media

Review your social media profiles and remove any information that is not necessary to have publicly visible. Your full date of birth, home address, phone number, and ID number should never appear on a public profile.

Read privacy policies before accepting

You do not need to read every single word, but you should at least scan a privacy policy for what information is being collected, whether it will be shared with third parties, how long it is kept, and how you can request deletion.

Only download apps from trusted sources

Download apps only from the official Google Play Store or Apple App Store. Before installing an app, check its permissions. If a simple torch app is asking for access to your contacts, your location, and your microphone, something is wrong.

Use strong and unique passwords

A strong password is at least 12 characters long and combines uppercase and lowercase letters, numbers, and special characters. Avoid using your name, date of birth, or student number as a password. If you struggle to remember multiple passwords, use a reputable password manager.

Enable two-factor authentication

Two-factor authentication adds an extra layer of security to your accounts. Even if someone gets hold of your password, they cannot access your account without the second form of verification. Enable 2FA on your email, banking app, and any other account that contains sensitive information.

Be careful on public Wi-Fi

Avoid accessing sensitive accounts such as your banking app, university portal, or email on unsecured public Wi-Fi networks. If you must use public Wi-Fi, consider using a VPN, which encrypts your internet traffic and makes it harder for others on the same network to intercept your data.

Verify before you click

If you receive an unexpected SMS, email, or WhatsApp message asking you to click a link or update your details, stop and verify before doing anything. Contact the organisation directly using a phone number or email address from their official website, not from the message itself.

Review app permissions regularly

Every few months, go through the apps on your phone and review what permissions each one has. Revoke any permissions that the app does not need for its core function. On Android, go to Settings then Privacy then Permission Manager. On iPhone, go to Settings then Privacy and Security.

Log out of shared devices

If you ever access your university portal, email, or any personal account on a shared or public computer, always log out completely when you are done. Do not simply close the browser tab. Clear the browsing history and cached data if possible.

Understanding What You Agree to When Accepting Terms and Conditions

Most people accept terms and conditions without reading them. Here are some of the most common things buried in terms and conditions that you should know about:

Data sharing with third parties

Many services include a clause that allows them to share your personal information with partners, affiliates, or service providers. Sometimes this is legitimate, but sometimes it means your information is being sold for advertising purposes.

Retention of data after account deletion

Some services keep your data for months or even years after you delete your account. The terms and conditions may simply say that data is kept "as long as necessary for business purposes", which can mean almost anything.

The right to change terms without notice

Many services include a clause stating they can update their terms and conditions at any time and that continued use of the service constitutes your acceptance of the new terms.

Where to Report Concerns in South Africa

Step 1: Contact the organisation directly. Put your concern in writing and send it to the organisation's Information Officer. Keep a copy of everything you send and receive.

Step 2: Contact the Information Regulator of South Africa:

- Website: www.inforegulator.org.za
- Email: inforeg@justice.gov.za
- Physical address: JD House, 27 Stiemens Street, Braamfontein, Johannesburg, 2001
- Telephone: 010 023 5207

Step 3: Seek legal advice if the matter involves significant harm such as identity theft or financial loss. Legal Aid South Africa provides free legal assistance to qualifying individuals.

Personal Privacy Audit Checklist

Complete the following checklist honestly for yourself. This is not submitted or graded. It is a tool to help you identify where you can improve your own digital privacy habits.

Privacy Habit	I do this consistently	I do this sometimes	I do not do this
I use unique passwords for different accounts			
I have enabled 2FA on my email and banking apps			
I review app permissions on my phone regularly			
I avoid using public Wi-Fi for sensitive accounts			
I check the sender details before clicking links in messages			
I read or scan privacy policies before signing up			
I log out of shared or public computers after use			
I avoid sharing sensitive documents in group chats			
I know how to contact the Information Regulator if needed			

I know who the Information Officer is for services I use			

If most of your answers fall in the "I do not do this" column, start with just two or three habits from this list and build from there. Small consistent changes make a big difference over time.

PART B: FINAL ASSESSMENT

This is the module's final assessment. Students must score 7 out of 10 to receive their digital badge.

Question 1

Which of the following is the most secure password?

A) Sipho1998

B) password123

C) UP@Student

D) Tr!angle92Blue# [CORRECT ANSWER]

Question 2

Thandi receives a WhatsApp message from what appears to be her bank, asking her to click a link and confirm her account details to avoid suspension. What should she do?

A) Click the link immediately to avoid her account being suspended

B) Reply to the message with her account details

C) Ignore the message and contact her bank directly using the number on their official website

D) Forward the message to her family members to warn them

Question 3

What does two-factor authentication do?

A) It creates two separate accounts for extra security

B) It requires a second form of verification in addition to your password

C) It doubles the length of your password automatically

D) It blocks all login attempts from unknown devices permanently

Question 4

A student notices that a flashlight app on their phone is requesting access to their contacts, microphone, and location. What should they do?

A) Grant all permissions because the app needs them to function properly

B) Delete the app immediately without checking further

C) Deny the unnecessary permissions and only allow what the app actually needs

D) Report the app to their university IT department

Question 5

Mpho wants to lodge a complaint about how a company handled his personal information. He already contacted the company but they did not respond. What is his next step?

A) Post about it on social media to warn others

B) Accept that nothing can be done and move on

C) Take the company to the High Court immediately

D) Lodge a formal complaint with the Information Regulator of South Africa

Question 6

Which of the following is a warning sign in a privacy policy?

A) The policy states how long your data will be kept

B) The policy provides contact details for the Information Officer

C) The policy says "we may share your data with selected partners from time to time" without specifying who

D) The policy explains your right to request deletion of your information

Question 7

Why should you avoid using the same password for multiple accounts?

A) Websites do not allow duplicate passwords across different platforms

B) If one account is compromised, all accounts using the same password become vulnerable

C) Passwords expire faster when they are reused

D) Search engines track repeated passwords and flag them as suspicious

Question 8

Lerato is using the free Wi-Fi at a shopping centre to check her banking app. What is the main risk?

A) Shopping centre Wi-Fi is too slow for banking apps to work properly

B) Her bank may charge her extra fees for using public Wi-Fi

C) Someone on the same network could potentially intercept her data

D) Her phone battery will drain faster on public Wi-Fi

Question 9

What should you do immediately after using a shared computer to access your university portal?

A) Restart the computer

B) Change your university portal password from your phone

C) Log out completely and clear the browsing history and cached data

D) Nothing, the session will expire on its own

Question 10

Which of the following best describes the purpose of POPIA as a whole?

A) To prevent South Africans from using the internet for personal activities

B) To protect individuals by regulating how organisations collect, store, use, and share personal information

C) To give the government access to all personal information stored by private companies

D) To allow organisations to collect any information they need as long as they store it securely